

UNSHACKLED TRUTH MEDIA

A NO-BS RECOVERY FIELD MANUAL &
RECKONING JOURNAL

THE FIRST 30

*Thirty days. One decision, made again and
again.*

*The journal for the hardest month of getting
clean.*

Chris Kelly

UNSHACKLED TRUTH MEDIA

THE FIRST 30

A No-BS Recovery Field Manual & Reckoning
Journal

Chris Kelly

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Important: This is a self-help companion written from lived experience, not medical or clinical advice. It is not a substitute for professional treatment, therapy, medication, or medical detox. Withdrawal from alcohol and some drugs can be dangerous or life-threatening — talk to a doctor before quitting. If you are in crisis, see the next page.

IF TODAY IS HEAVY — READ THIS FIRST

You don't have to white-knuckle it alone.

Reaching out is not weakness. It's the move. These are free, confidential, and open right now:

SUBSTANCE USE & TREATMENT

SAMHSA National Helpline

1-800-662-4357

24/7 · free · confidential · English & Spanish

CRISIS & SUICIDE SUPPORT

988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline

Call or text 988

24/7 · free · confidential

If you slipped: a relapse is a detour, not a dead end, and it does not erase the days you strung together. Get honest, get safe, and start the next clean day. Shame keeps people using; starting again beats it. Turn the page and keep going.

HOW THIS WORKS

Five minutes a day. That's the whole ask.

This isn't a diary you fall behind on and quit. It's a field manual for thirty days — one page a day, morning or night, whenever you'll actually do it. Every day has the same four parts:

- 01** **THE TRUTH.** A short, straight read from someone who's been where you are. No lectures. Read it slow.
- 02** **GUT CHECK.** One honest question and room to answer it. Nobody grades this. Write ugly and true, not neat and fake.
- 03** **TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG.** Track what hit you and what you did instead. Patterns you can see are patterns you can beat.
- 04** **ONE MOVE.** A single doable action for the day. Not your whole life — just the next right thing.

Miss a day? Don't restart, don't quit — just pick up on the next one. Progress here is measured in showing up, not in perfect streaks. Print it, or write on it on a tablet. However you'll actually use it is the right way.

WEEK ONE

SURVIVE

*Right now the only job is to still be clean when
your head hits the pillow.*

DAYS 1-7

YOU SHOWED UP

THE TRUTH

Nobody claps for day one. There's no chip, no crowd, no finish line in sight — just you and a decision you have to make again in about twenty minutes. That's fine. I've started over more times than I can count, and every clean stretch I ever strung together started exactly here: shaky, unsure, and still standing. You don't have to believe you'll make it. You just have to not use today.

GUT CHECK

Why now? What finally made this attempt different from the last time you told yourself you'd quit? Write it down before the feeling fades — you'll need to read it back on a hard day.

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME

0-10

WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Get rid of what's in reach. Pour it out, flush it, hand it over. Remove one thing you could use tonight.

THE FOG

THE TRUTH

Your body is renegotiating a deal it made a long time ago, and it is not being polite about it. The headache, the sweats, the wired-but-exhausted feeling — that's not weakness, that's chemistry. It passes. Drink water, eat something even if you don't want to, and stop expecting yourself to think clearly. Survival is the whole assignment today.

GUT CHECK

How does your body actually feel right now — not what you think you should say, the real inventory? Naming it takes some of its power away.

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME

0-10

WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Do one physical thing your body needs: eat a real meal, take a shower, or sleep. Pick one and do it.

“JUST ONE”

THE TRUTH

The most expensive sentence in my life was 'just one.' Just one drink, just one hit, just this once because today was hard. Your brain will offer it to you like a friend doing you a favor. It is not your friend. 'Just one' is the trailer for a movie you've already seen, and you know exactly how it ends.

GUT CHECK

Write out the full tape of 'just one' — not the first ten minutes, the whole thing. Where were you 48 hours after the last 'just one'?

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME

0-10

WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Name your 'just one' voice. Call it something. When it talks today, say the name out loud so you know who's asking.

THE PHONE

THE TRUTH

There are numbers in your phone that are not people — they're on-ramps. The dealer, the drinking buddy who only knows you loaded, the ex you call when you want an excuse. You don't have to give a speech. You don't owe them a goodbye. You just delete, block, and let them wonder. Distance isn't rude. Distance is oxygen.

GUT CHECK

Who in your contacts is a direct line back to using? List them by name. You're not judging them — you're mapping the minefield.

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME

0-10

WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Delete or block one number that only leads one direction. One is enough for today.

THE WAVE

THE TRUTH

A craving feels like it will last forever and kill you if you don't feed it. Both of those are lies. A craving is a wave — it builds, it peaks, and if you don't paddle out to meet it, it breaks and rolls back out. Most peak in under twenty minutes. You have survived every single one so far, including the ones that felt unsurvivable. Your record is perfect.

GUT CHECK

What does a craving actually feel like in your body — where does it live, how does it move? Describe it like a weather report, not a verdict.

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME

0-10

WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Next craving today: set a timer for 15 minutes and just outlast it. Note below what happened.

EMPTY HOURS

THE TRUTH

The drug didn't just get you high — it ate your time. Now there's all this raw, echoing space where using used to live, and empty time is dangerous time. Boredom isn't harmless for people like us; it's the room where the old voice gets loud. You don't need a five-year plan. You need to know what you're doing at 8 p.m. tonight when it gets quiet.

GUT CHECK

When during the day are you most likely to slip — what time, what setting, what mood? Pin down your danger window.

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME

0-10

WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Plan your danger window for today. Write down exactly what you'll be doing during it, and with who if possible.

ONE WEEK

THE TRUTH

Seven days. Say it out loud. A week ago you weren't sure you could do a single hour, and you just stacked a hundred and sixty-eight of them. Don't get cocky — week one is where the fog lifts just enough to make you think you've got this handled, and thinking you've got it handled is how a lot of good weeks end. Be proud and stay low. Both.

GUT CHECK

What surprised you this week — about how hard it was, how strong you were, or both? Mark the milestone honestly.

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME

0-10

WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Do one thing to mark seven days that isn't a substance — a good meal, a call to someone safe, a walk. Reward the work.

WEEK TWO

RECKON

*The fog is lifting. Now you look at what it cost —
clear-eyed, not crushed.*

DAYS 8-14

THE WRECKAGE

THE TRUTH

The high covered a lot. Now that it's clearing, you're going to see the mess it was hiding — the bills, the burned bridges, the things you said, the year you can't fully account for. Don't look away and don't drown in it. This isn't a courtroom, it's a damage report. You can't rebuild what you refuse to look at. Take the inventory. Then keep going.

GUT CHECK

What did using actually cost you — name three real things? Money, people, time, trust, health. Be specific, not dramatic.

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME	0-10	WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Pick one small piece of wreckage you can start cleaning up today: one email, one apology text, one bill you look at.

THE PEOPLE

THE TRUTH

Here's the part that hurts more than any hangover: the people you love got the worst version of you. I carried that for years. But there's a difference between owning harm and rotting in it. Guilt says 'I did something bad' and can be repaired. Shame says 'I am bad' and just keeps you sick. Feel the guilt, use it as fuel, and refuse the shame — it was never going to help anyone you hurt.

GUT CHECK

Who got the worst of it? Write to them here — not to send yet, just to be honest on paper about what you'd want them to know.

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME

0-10

WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Separate one guilt from one shame today. Write 'I did ___' and 'I am not ___'. Say the second one out loud.

THE MONEY

THE TRUTH

Addiction is expensive in a way that compounds — the substance, the missed work, the things you sold, the debt that grew in the dark. Money shame keeps a lot of people using because facing the number feels worse than staying numb. It isn't. A number is just a number, and every clean day you're not feeding the hole is a day the math starts working for you instead of against you.

GUT CHECK

Roughly what was the habit costing you a week? Multiply it out for a month. What could that money build instead?

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME

0-10

WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Do one concrete money thing: check a balance, list a debt, or calculate this week's savings from not using.

THE VOICE

THE TRUTH

There's a narrator in your head that has been on the payroll of your addiction for years. It sounds like you. It uses your logic, your memories, your excuses. 'You've earned it.' 'One won't hurt.' 'You're not even that bad.' The single most useful skill in recovery is learning to hear that voice and know it isn't you — it's the disease wearing your face. You don't have to obey a voice just because it sounds familiar.

GUT CHECK

Write down the exact lines your addict voice uses on you. Get them on paper where you can see them for what they are.

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME

0-10

WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Catch the voice once today and answer it out loud. Talk back to it like the liar it is.

HALF-TRUTHS

THE TRUTH

I was a great liar, and the best lies I told were the ones I told myself. 'I only use on weekends.' 'I can stop whenever.' 'It's not affecting anyone.' Getting clean means the half-truths have to go too, because the space between the story and the facts is exactly where a relapse hides. You don't have to confess to the world. But you have to stop lying to the one person who can't leave: you.

GUT CHECK

What's one lie you've been telling yourself about your using that you already know isn't true? Write the truth next to it.

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME

0-10

WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Tell one true thing today you'd normally soften or hide — to yourself in writing, or to one safe person.

THE HALFWAY LIE

THE TRUTH

Two weeks in, the brain plays a new trick: 'See? You're basically fine now. You proved your point. You could probably handle it in moderation.' This is the single most dangerous thought in early recovery, and almost everyone gets it right around here. Feeling better is not the same as being cured. The plan didn't stop working — it's working. That's why you feel better.

GUT CHECK

Have you caught yourself thinking you could go back to 'controlled' use? Write out what actually happened last time you tried moderation.

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME

0-10

WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Reread your Day One entry — why you started. Reconnect to it before the halfway lie talks you out of it.

TWO WEEKS

THE TRUTH

Fourteen days. The physical worst is mostly behind you, and what's left is the long game — the mental, the emotional, the rebuilding. That's actually good news, even if it doesn't feel triumphant. The hardest chemistry is done. Now it's a project you can actually work on with a clear-ish head. Steady beats dramatic. You're steady.

GUT CHECK

What's different in your head today versus Day One? Even small clarity counts — mark it so you can see the progress.

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME

0-10

WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Tell one person you trust that you've made two weeks. Saying it out loud makes it real and builds your net.

WEEK THREE

REBUILD

*You stop reacting and start engineering the life
that doesn't need it.*

DAYS 15-21

TRIGGERS, MAPPED

THE TRUTH

A trigger isn't magic — it's a pattern, and patterns can be mapped. People, places, feelings, times of day, certain songs, certain streets. When you know your triggers by name, they stop ambushing you and start becoming things you can plan around. The goal isn't to avoid life forever; it's to stop walking into the same three traps blind. Map them, and you take back the terrain.

GUT CHECK

List your top five triggers — be specific. Not 'stress,' but 'Sunday nights,' 'driving past the old spot,' 'texts from ____.'

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME

0-10

WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Pick your #1 trigger and write one plan for it: avoid it, or a specific move for when you can't.

WHO STAYS

THE TRUTH

Some people in your life only make sense when you're using. That's a hard sentence, but you already know which ones. Getting clean sorts your circle whether you like it or not — some people root for the new you, and some quietly liked the old you better because it made them feel okay about themselves. Protect the sobriety over the friendship. The right people will understand. The wrong ones proving they're wrong is information, not loss.

GUT CHECK

Sort your closest people into two lists: who makes staying clean easier, and who makes it harder. Be honest, even when it stings.

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME

0-10

WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Reach out to one person from the 'easier' list today. Connection is a relapse-prevention tool, not a luxury.

H.A.L.T.

THE TRUTH

Four words have saved my sobriety more times than any big philosophy: Hungry, Angry, Lonely, Tired. When the craving hits hard for no reason, run the checklist — nine times out of ten one of those four is cranked up and the addiction is just exploiting it. You're not actually failing. You're hungry. Or exhausted. Fix the real thing and the 'craving' often just deflates.

GUT CHECK

Which of the four hits you hardest and pushes you toward using — Hungry, Angry, Lonely, or Tired? How does it show up?

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME

0-10

WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Run H.A.L.T. on yourself right now. Whichever one is high, take one action to bring it down today.

THE HOLE IT FILLED

THE TRUTH

Nobody gets addicted to feeling bad. The drug did a job for you — it numbed something, quieted something, made something bearable. If you rip it out and put nothing in the hole, the hole just screams until you feed it again. Recovery isn't only subtraction. You have to figure out what the using was actually for, and start meeting that need in a way that doesn't cost you everything.

GUT CHECK

Be honest: what did using do for you? Numb pain, kill boredom, silence anxiety, help you belong? Name the real job it did.

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME

0-10

WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Pick one healthier thing that touches that same need and try it today, even badly. First rep counts.

THE PLAN

THE TRUTH

Hope is not a relapse plan. You need something written down for the moment the craving is winning — because in that moment your thinking brain is offline and you'll do whatever's easiest. So make the right thing the easiest thing, now, while you're clear. Who you call. Where you go. What you do for the next ten minutes. Cravings don't schedule appointments. Have the plan before you need it.

GUT CHECK

Write your emergency plan: 2 people you'll call, 1 place you'll go, and the first 3 things you'll do when a craving spikes.

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME

0-10

WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Put your plan somewhere you'll actually find it — phone notes, wallet, fridge. Test that you can reach one contact right now.

ASKING FOR HELP

THE TRUTH

For a long time I thought needing help was proof I was weak. Turns out it was proof I was human, and the guys I know who made it are the ones who stopped trying to white-knuckle it alone. A meeting, a sponsor, a counselor, a hotline, one honest friend — the form doesn't matter. Isolation is the addiction's favorite environment. You get better in rooms with other people, not alone in your head.

GUT CHECK

What's stopped you from asking for help — pride, shame, not knowing where? Name the block so you can step around it.

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME

0-10

WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Take one step toward support today: look up one meeting, call the SAMHSA line (1-800-662-4357), or text one person the truth.

THREE WEEKS

THE TRUTH

Twenty-one days. They say it takes about that long for a habit to start setting, and you can probably feel it — some of this is getting slightly less white-knuckle. Slightly. Don't confuse a groove for a guarantee, but do notice it. The routines you've been forcing are starting to hold their own shape. That's not luck. That's three weeks of you choosing, over and over, when it would've been easier not to.

GUT CHECK

What's one new routine that's actually starting to feel normal? Give the habit credit — it's carrying weight now.

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME	0-10	WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Reinforce one habit that's working. Do it again today, on purpose, and notice it getting easier.

WEEK FOUR

BECOME

*Thirty days doesn't fix you. It proves you can.
Here's who you're becoming.*

DAYS 22-28

WITHOUT IT

THE TRUTH

So much of who you thought you were got tangled up with using — the parties, the edge, the story you told about being a certain kind of person. Take that away and there's a scary question underneath: who am I without it? Here's the truth I found on the other side. You were never the drug. It was covering the actual person, not creating him. That guy's still in there. You're about to meet him sober, maybe for the first time in years.

GUT CHECK

Who were you before it took over — what did you love, what were you good at, what lit you up? Reach back and write it down.

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME

0-10

WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Do one thing today the sober version of you would do — something the using you had no time for. Reintroduce yourself.

THE BODY COMES BACK

THE TRUTH

Somewhere in here you'll notice it: you slept through the night, food tastes like something again, you caught your reflection and didn't flinch. The body is stubborn and forgiving — give it a few clean weeks and it starts handing pieces of you back. These wins are quiet and easy to miss. Don't miss them. They're the receipts that this is working on the inside, not just the outside.

GUT CHECK

What physical thing has come back — sleep, appetite, energy, a clearer face? Log the wins your body is giving you.

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME	0-10	WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Do one thing that helps your body keep healing: a walk, real food, water, an early night. Bank the recovery.

AMENDS, CAREFULLY

THE TRUTH

You're going to want to fix everything with the people you hurt, all at once, right now. Slow down. Amends done recklessly are often more about relieving your own guilt than actually helping them, and showing up dramatically can reopen a wound on someone else's schedule instead of yours. Some amends are words. Some are just becoming a person who doesn't do it again and letting time prove it. Don't set yourself back trying to prove you've changed. Change, quietly, and let it show.

GUT CHECK

Who do you owe an amends? For each, ask: would reaching out help them, or just relieve me? Sort it honestly.

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME

0-10

WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Where it's safe and welcome, make one small, genuine amends today — no grand speech, just honest and brief.

A REASON

THE TRUTH

White-knuckle willpower runs out. What lasts is a reason — something you're staying clean FOR, not just something you're running from. A kid, a craft, a faith, a version of your life you actually want to reach. When the want-to-use gets loud, a strong enough why can be louder. Find yours and keep it in front of you, because 'I don't want to feel like garbage' will only carry you so far up the hill.

GUT CHECK

What are you getting sober FOR — not away from, toward? Write the reason big enough to fight for.

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME

0-10

WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Put your reason somewhere you'll see it every day. A note, a photo, a lock screen. Make the why unavoidable.

THE BORING MIRACLE

THE TRUTH

Here's the secret nobody tells you: the reward for recovery is a normal Tuesday. Paying your bills. Answering your phone without dread. Remembering the whole conversation. It sounds like a letdown after the chaos, but that boring, ordinary, unremarkable peace IS the miracle — it's the exact thing the drug kept promising and never delivered. Learn to love the quiet. You bled for it.

GUT CHECK

What ordinary thing can you do now that you couldn't a month ago? Notice the boring miracle and let it count.

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME

0-10

WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Fully enjoy one ordinary thing today — coffee, a show, a real conversation — present, clear-headed, no chaser.

WHEN NOBODY'S WATCHING

THE TRUTH

Early on, some of staying clean is for other people — to prove something, to stop disappointing someone. That's fine as training wheels, but real sobriety is what you do when no one would ever know. Alone in the house. Cash in your pocket. A bad day and a clear opportunity. The man you are in that unwatched moment is the real one. Start being sober for him, not for the audience.

GUT CHECK

When you're completely alone and no one would find out — that's your real test. How do you do in that moment, honestly?

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME

0-10

WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Today, do the right thing in one small moment no one will see. Build the private version of sober.

PLAY IT FORWARD

THE TRUTH

The craving always shows you the first frame — the relief, the warmth, the exhale. It never shows you frame two hundred: the sick, the lies, the person you'd have to look at tomorrow, the counter reset to zero. So play the tape all the way forward yourself. Don't stop at the high. Follow it to the bathroom floor, the missed call, the Day One you'd have to start over. Then decide if the first frame's still worth it.

GUT CHECK

Play your relapse all the way through — not the first hit, the full aftermath. Write where it actually ends. Every time.

TRIGGER & CRAVING LOG

WHAT HIT ME

0-10

WHAT I DID INSTEAD



ONE MOVE TODAY

Practice it once today on paper: crave → full tape → what you'll do instead.
Rehearse the escape before you need it.

WHERE TO GO FROM HERE

Thirty days down. The story doesn't stop here.

Everything in this journal came out of the same place my book did — the real thing, the falling apart and the clawing back. If this helped, that's the next step:

THE CRACKS BENEATH THE SURFACE

The full memoir — how it fell apart, and how I got out.

Unshackled Truth Media

Keep the counter going. Start a second 30 in this same journal, join a room, make the call. And if you know someone still in the dark — send them their own copy. That's how the light spreads.

— Chris Kelly

THE FIRST 30

*“You don’t have to believe you’ll make it.
You just have to not use today. Do that
thirty times and look what you’ve got.”*

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